

G R E G H E F F L E Y

a psychological analysis.



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GREG HEFFLEY: PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

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Introduction

A ‘sociopath’ is a person with a personality disorder that manifests itself into extremely antisocial attitudes, and a lack of conscience. They can be manipulative, irresponsible, inconsistent and... you’ve probably interacted with one without even noticing. Yes, most of the sociopaths you’ll meet throughout your life will probably never be diagnosed as a sociopath; and even if they are, they’re probably not extreme enough for it to be relevant.

On the other side of the ring is the children’s book series, ‘Diary of A Wimpy Kid’. It’s a bit influential, a satirical comedy novel for young adults. They center around Greg Heffley, and his struggles through middle school. Sure, it sounds a bit played out, but it’s presentation was what made it feel new. When the first book released online, there weren’t too many stories quite like the Diary of a Wimpy Kid series, though now it’s a bit of a trope. Canonically, each of the series’ installments are supposed to be the main character’s personal diary.

“It’s a journal, not a diary”

Right, I’m sorry. It’s quite a unique concept to do this, being able to showcase a story in a ‘he-said she-said’ type manner; but that’s not the point of this video / document. The main point of this document... video... whatever revolves around a side effect of this storytelling method. Because this is supposedly written from Greg Heffley’s perspective, it can give us a sense of how HE thinks, views and acts. With these journals, we’re able to pull out a semi-accurate view of his mindset. Yes, as you’ve probably read from the title, this is going to be an in-depth analysis of Greg Heffley’s (currently 11) journals. I’m going to be clear, though; the following points are centered more around a personal theory of mine; and that is whether or not Greg Heffley is actually a sociopath. This may sound a bit farfetched at first, but as the points go on you may get more and more convinced.

Grandiose Sense of Self

Grandiosity is a term that usually refers to a person’s false delusions of grandeur. While this trait often resides in narcissists, it’s not solely limited to them. Grandiosity is usually when a person expects to be recognized for their importance, despite not truly having done anything worthwhile or extraordinary. This can range from exaggerating achievements, feats, and accomplishments. Greg Heffley fits very nicely under this label.

Let’s tackle the first part of the definition; lying about their accomplishments. Greg seems to do this a lot, usually when attempting to impress a peer. When Rowley had broken his arm, Greg tries to impress others by claiming he also had an injury, when in reality he was completely fine. In ‘Double

Down', he attempts to impress a college student he had just met by saying that he was an expert in psychology.

Onto the second half of the definition, which is when someone expects to be recognized for their importance. Greg has, and always will view himself as someone who will get famous in the future, while his friends family members will be leeches, mooching off of his popularity. He even predicts that Rowley will apparently cash in by writing about his experience with Greg as a child. His expectation of popularity is the whole reason he began writing into the diary in the first place; he expected to be so popular that in the future, he would be too busy or important to answer questions from the public. He seems to rank himself on an imaginary scale, against all the other kids in the school district. In this chart, the closer you are to the top, the more popular you are with others. In 'Double Down', Greg recounts a story about a special education group he was put in titled 'The Champs'. He depicts him and the other kids being the 'cool' ones, as everyone turned to praise them during recess. In reality, this is likely just an exaggeration Greg created to impress the reader, as there's no real reason for this outside of name.

Greg's view of himself is so high, that he seems to suspect that his life has some kind of ulterior, greater meaning. He believes that there's some sort of television show, where people would watch his life constantly. In one image (drawn by Greg, by the way), it shows his mother after giving birth, while he stared into a mirror talking to his 'audience'. If Greg thinks this will impress the reader, then he is extremely mistaken. I've spoken to many others about this, but the way he portrays events in the newest book feels very bizarre comparatively, as he discusses his insane dreams and theories in detail.

Manipulative and Conning

To be 'manipulative and conning' is to be a person that will take advantage of people for self gain, often to also humiliate them. I'm sure you've met at least one person like this, a person that doesn't really view others with respect, and just see them as tools for their own success. A 'tool' is an accurate description of how Greg views his supposed best friend, Rowley Jefferson.

Rowley Jefferson is a chubby, neighborhood friend that moved into the area early in Greg's life. He's very kind hearted, and often just wants to be himself, no matter how it's viewed by others. Greg... views Rowley as an idiot, someone he's 'above' both mentally, physically, and on the scale. He thinks of Rowley as an immature child, repeatedly attacking him for things like using improper terminology (which, by the way, is extremely subjective). While Rowley isn't the brightest child, he's not really someone who deserves the treatment Greg gives to him. Greg belittles him, acts as a superior rather than a peer, and he even tricks him for his own amusement.

In the first book, Greg forces Rowley to ride down a large hill with a children's bicycle, while he tried to hit him with a football. Note that Greg refused to take turns, and insisted on being the one throwing. When he finally managed to hit Rowley, he ended up accidentally breaking Rowley's arm, forcing him to have to wear a cast. The injury brings Rowley some attention, and he starts becoming a bit

popular because of it. Greg sees this, and attempts to use Rowley's injury as a way to get some popularity for himself. It backfires, as you'd expect.

In *Dog Days*, Greg tries to start up a lawn mowing service to earn himself some extra revenue. This is the result of a long series of events, but in summary he needed to pay a bill that he owed to Rowley's father. Despite being Greg's idea, and Greg's bill, Greg attempted to trick Rowley into doing all of the labor that came with the job. When Rowley refused, Greg got upset and didn't understand why Rowley didn't want to obey. This was enough for Rowley, and he was so fed up with Greg he decided to take another break from him. Greg didn't seem to understand Rowley was so upset, and just brushed him off as being selfish.

Greg's manipulation is no secret, either. Greg Heffley's own wikipedia page contains an excerpt relating to how Greg would take advantage of Rowley's good nature.

“Greg's best friend is Rowley Jefferson, who takes part in Greg's schemes, and is sometimes a victim of Greg's manipulation and deception.”

Greg is only friends with Rowley for selfish reasons. Rowley is almost always wrapped into his schemes, and gets the short end of the stick; from his ill-fated ad campaigns, production of comic strips, or even just setting up jokes. Greg obliterates this qualification. The fact that Greg treats Rowley so poorly, despite all of the things he's done to help him is just honestly disgusting. I hope that one day, there's a true last straw for Rowley, and he gets away from that manipulative bastard.

Superficial Charmer

A superficial charmer, also known as an 'insincere charmer', is when a person attempts to 'charm' or manipulate someone for an unclear or ulterior motive. While Greg doesn't seem to succeed at many of his attempts, he definitely tries. Most of his failed charming occur at school, where things just seem to not go his way. One example of this is with Abigail Brown in the 'Third Wheel'. Greg learns that she has recently broken up with her boyfriend, and pursues her for the dance. She doesn't go with him, however, and chooses his wingman Rowley instead.

Strangely, the people Greg is the best at charming is his own family. He'll constantly makes empty promises to his parents, that often relate to a new trend or gimmick that he abandons almost immediately after. This happens multiple times in multiple books. The weightlifting machine, the french horn, the dog, these are all things Greg impulsively asked his parents to buy, and then almost immediately abandoned. He charmed them with his promises of new activities, skills, and hope. It's almost shocking to see Greg manipulate his parents so well like this, considering how unsuccessful he is at school; I guess it speaks measures about how Greg views them. Greg's failure at charming is likely the reason why he constantly brings up his lack of love life. He often laments about how he should be popular, because he was the one who stood by their side all the way back in elementary school. If he's willing to write about it

in his personal journal, it isn't too much of a stretch to say that he would try to tell his classmates for some popularity.

One of the few successful charms Greg has had with a peer involved 'Fregley', the apparent weird kid that lives in his neighborhood. While Greg has repeatedly made fun of Fregley in the journal, it seems that when Greg has no other choice, he was all for using Fregley as a tool as well. Back in the first book, when Rowley decided to ditch Greg for throwing him under the bus, Greg began thinking about new potential 'best friends'. Greg weighed his options, and decided to be friends with Fregley only because of his loneliness; he always had an ulterior motive for befriending Fregley, and simply wanted to use Fregley for his own benefit. He 'charmed' him by offering to be his only friend, something that Fregley would never refuse. Greg fed on his vulnerability.

"Many narcissists brag about their wealth, health, possessions, collections, spouses, children, personal history, family tree – in short: anything that garners them attention and renders them alluring."

I feel extremely sympathetic towards Fregley, and the way he was mistreated by Greg. If there's one thing that isn't discussed much in the series, it's the fact that Fregley is much better off without Greg as a friend. With a friend like that, who needs enemies?

Pathological Liar

Greg is extremely elaborate in his lies and beliefs, and often gets caught up in them. He'll go on and on about things that simply cannot be true, things that he had to have fabricated. For example, in the 'Third Wheel', Greg claims to remember the time that he spent in his mother's womb. He wrote about how he had begun laying in the family's bathtub for hours, trying to recreate the feeling of being a fetus. This 'feeling' he was trying to recreate is impossible to achieve, for more reasons than one. There are many studies that prove that you will not remember anything from when you were a fetus. It is likely that Greg is just lying, and only created this story after resting in the bathtub for hours on end.

Greg often tries to underplay himself to the teachers when they are evaluating his intelligence. In an elaborate scheme he had come up with, he attempted to throw a test by pretending to be unable to read a young children's book. The test was to evaluate his intelligence so they could place him in the correct classes. The teachers were able to see through this, but still, the fact that he attempted it says a lot about his character.

As mentioned before, Greg also has a strange belief in which his life is the center of its own television show; that his whole world is a facade for others to watch and enjoy. His descriptions of these beliefs go on for nearly fifteen pages of his journal, and it's extremely bizarre. While Greg seems to love lying to himself, he also won't hesitate to lie to others. In Double Down, Greg attempts to lie to his mother about a bully that apparently would 'eat his fruits' at school. Greg claimed that he was being picked on by a larger student (that didn't exist, by the way), and claimed in his diary that he 'described the bully in detail' because he knew that his mother would believe him with that extra information. His

mother believed everything, and went to the school board only to then find out that Greg had lied. This seems to prove that Greg is able to formulate an incredibly convincing story that spans over a long period of time. He's able to pick up on aspects that would make his story more believable to others. This proves that he is able to pathologically lie with ease.

Lack of Guilt or Shame

Greg almost never regrets what he's done, no matter the consequence. Wait, wait, no. That's not exactly right. No matter the consequence- for others. He doesn't care or regret anything unless they backfire, and the negativity is on him. He often doesn't try to relate, or empathize with other students, which seems to contribute to the idea of his peers being obstacles to his goal of popularity. In the 'Long Haul', Greg accuses another family, the 'Beardos', of stealing his family's possessions. He thinks that the Beardos stole the keys to their locker, because he was unable to find it at the seating. They ask an employee there to help open the Heffley families' locker, and only Greg is able to recall the number. The employee opens it up, only to find that it's empty. Greg sees this as proof of the Beardos stealing their property, and alerts everyone of his suspicions.

Since we're bringing this plot point up, obviously, Greg's hatred of the Beardos is not justified. As it turns out, no. He was wrong; at the end of the trip, Greg returns home, and finds the family's keys in his pocket. He then learns that he not only had the key the whole time, but he also misremembered the locker number. This means that the family's belongings are still in the locker, and that the Beardos were innocent. Upon realizing his mistake, Greg doesn't feel shame, or remorse for essentially throwing an entire family under the bus; he simply thinks up of ways he can dispose or excuse it. Sure, he considers telling his parents, but honestly this is never officially stated, which makes it doubtful that he went with the high ground.

He also didn't feel remorse when he broke Rowley's arm in the first book; think about it. He didn't feel remorse when injuring his best friend. He instead got jealous of him for his new founded attention; and that's really telling. This seems to be a common theme throughout his 11 journals; he always brushes off his mistakes, he never feels shame, and when he does it's only for selfish reasons.

"Instead of friends, they have victims and accomplices who end up as victims. The end always justifies the means and they let nothing stand in their way."

Shallow Emotions

Greg rarely shows compassion or joy to others in the series. The iconic blank stare he makes is all too common in the series... it's used so much, just the frown is enough to identify his character. What makes the heavy usage of this face strange is the fact that, remember; these are not actual scenes, but Greg's own interpretations of scenes. When thrown birthday parties, instead of depicting an image of him enjoying the party, he writes about how much he hated the guests, or how'd they play with all of his toys. Many recollections he's written about events are events that should be emotional, but he doesn't seem to

feel anything towards it. When he does show joy, it's usually when everyone around him is, so it's impossible to determine whether or not he's genuinely happy, or he's just setting up the facade to make his life look more eventful, ala Christmas Party. It's as if he's trying to fit in because he's 'with the popular kids', and doesn't want to ruin the party.

Greg does not sympathise with Rowley whenever Greg inadvertently screws him over. A key example of this is in the first book. Greg's mother, Susan, tells him that he should apologize to Rowley for what he thinks he did wrong. Greg, unable to understand the scope and nature of the situation, apologizes to Rowley happily, and expects no repercussions whatsoever. He doesn't understand that Rowley still had to deal with Greg's actions, and that Greg just seemed to be gloating, or unsympathetic. Hell, afterwards, Greg admits feeling that he deserved to be rewarded for this supposed amazing apology, an apology that he only did because he felt only a little bit of pressure.

Need for Stimulation

Typically, the term 'need for stimulation' refers to gambling, or drug abuse. With *Diary of a Wimpy Kid*, a book aimed towards juveniles, we won't really be seeing how he turned out as an adult, and thus no adult themes. Instead, the comparison to Greg leans more towards his will to physically abuse his little brother, Manny. In many books, he writes about how he wishes he could beat and abuse him, whether it be practical jokes, or destroying his creations. In fact, he'd likely go through with these plans, had Manny had not been constantly watched by their parents. His disgusting need to abuse someone is fulfilled by his 'friendship' with Rowley, which seems to be just another way Greg takes advantage of his alleged 'lower intelligence'. Greg will play practical jokes that he thinks are harmless, but can end up with Rowley seriously injured.

Greg also feeds on video games, and has an unhealthy obsession with the medium. He often uses Rowley's system when he is grounded, and is able to sneak inappropriate games past his father. At one point, Greg forced Rowley to camp with him outside of a video game store for the entire night, just to be at the front of the line. Their labors were hardly fruitful, and Greg ended up getting his hand severely injured. Likely deservedly.

Lack of Empathy

If the past examples have not convinced you that Greg lacks empathy, this section hopefully will. Examples of his lack of empathy are scattered all throughout the series. Greg writes about how much he hated being left out, and this is even more clear with his wishes to become popular; he wants to be a 'cool kid'. He even wrote about being upset when he was forced to leave the 'Champs'. Well, despite being an outcast, Greg has no empathy for other kids in the same or similar situation. Remember when Rowley ditched Greg for throwing him under the bus, and Greg went to Fregley? Well, after Greg and Rowley became friends again, Greg began to, again, completely ignore Fregley. While Fregley is definitely not a 'normal' kid, I don't think it's acceptable to just spy on him from inside, while he waits outside of your home for hours on end.

Greg has made it clear that when he was much younger, Rodrick would bully him, breaking his toys and lying to him to humiliate him. Despite being at the back end of this abuse, Greg doesn't want to help prevent others from going through his pain. He instead wants to inflict the pain he received to someone else. First Manny, and now Rowley, Greg seems to have an unhealthy lack of empathy and, as a result, hypocrisy.

Impulsive Nature

You'll probably remember when we mentioned that Greg has often 'charmed' his parents into purchasing expensive items for his quickly thought out ideas; well, those examples also double as showcases for his impulsive nature. Greg doesn't always think before he speaks, and will do things without realizing the consequences. This happened with Rowley's father's membership, where he would constantly order drinks assuming it had been paid for. This racked up so much money, that Rowley's father had to confront Greg about the bill. Greg's impulsiveness can lead to him getting in lots of trouble. In the first book, he and Rowley decide to out for trick or treating on Halloween. Near the end of their course, a group of teenagers pull up, and spray the two with water as a prank. Greg immediately yells at the teenagers, claiming that he was going to 'call the police'. This led to a chase that ended with the two hiding out in his Grandma's house, while the teenagers vandalised her property. It's worth noting that when seeing the wreckage the next day, he expressed a little bit of remorse, but justified it in his own mind,

Juvenile Delinquency

I'd like to read a quote from the source I'm using, which lists the various traits and signs of someone being a potential sociopath. Remember; while this isn't the end all be all, these traits can be extremely helpful in identifying sociopaths.

"...Usually has a history of behavioral and academic difficulties, yet "gets by" by conning others. Problems in making and keeping friends; aberrant behaviors such as cruelty to people or animals, stealing, etc. "

Does this sound familiar to you? Because to me, it sounds like an almost perfect description of Greg Heffley. Greg is horrible at school, often slacking off and wishing that he got into a lower level class. He once slept through an entire period, only to wake up in the middle of the next. He's conned others before, and tried to use his brother's old essay to trick the teacher into giving him a good grade. This backfired of course, but his intention still hold true. He's had many issues keeping just one friend, and his mistreatment of Rowley often leads to fights and arguments that end in long break ups. Greg has also admitted to stealing many times throughout the diaries, and hid a relative's diamond ring so that when she died, others wouldn't be able to find it.

Unreliability

Greg has horrible memory, and often forgets to do simple tasks that lead to detrimental results; see the Beardos situation. He also is irresponsible, and is willing to destroy other people's reputations to save his own skin. This happened with the safety patrol, where he bullied kindergarteners and chased them with worms. At one point, he forced them to climb and hide in a hole that was made in a construction area. A neighbor saw this, and assumed that it was Rowley who had chased the children. Greg didn't correct them, and Rowley was forced to resign and apologize to the children. Greg didn't seem to care, and assumed things would be better after telling Rowley that it was him. We already know how badly that went, however.

At a school play Greg had been cast in, Greg had an extremely simple role; his role was to literally play a tree, stand still for most of the show; somehow, he was able to mess even this simple task up. He completely derailed the show, and at one point threw a prop at the main lead. The main actor became upset, and attacked Greg, devolving the play into a fight. Greg wasn't even remorseful of wasting all of the time and effort his peers had put into the show; instead, he wrote about how proud he was of this achievement.

Promiscuous Sexual Behavior/Infidelity

To be frank, this section is not eligible for the analysis. Since Greg is only a child, he does not have any known sexual behaviour, nonetheless casual ones. Thus, please understand why this aspect of sociopathy was discluded from the list. With that said, however, I do believe that in the future, when Greg is fully grown up, he will do something to qualify in this category.

Parasitic Lifestyle

While Greg only currently lives with his parents, his future is not looking very bright. As of the latest book, Double Down, his aspiration in life is to be an overweight, bearded video game tester who sits at home all day instead of socializing. This is very parasitic, and it's assumed that he is mooching off of his parents while doing so. This is never clarified, however.

Criminal or Entrepreneurial Versatility

Criminal or entrepreneurial versatility refers to a person 'changing their image as needed to avoid prosecution'. They can change their life story readily. I think you can see where this is going. Greg has supposedly been in middle school for more years than possible. It seems he hasn't aged in the whole series, he's had two summers and remained in the same grade. This is where my true theory kicks in. Greg Heffley changes his story in the diary to make himself seem more important, seem more interesting for when the supposed public reads his stories in the future. This is supported by past events. Think back

to the vacation photos he created in the Last Straw. He would photoshop himself into images of others having fun, so his life wouldn't seem lame. It seems that there's some kind of discrepancy between the timeline, it doesn't work for him to still be in middle school. He HAS to be rewriting some of his years in middle school for this to make sense. Greg claims to have memory from when he was in the womb; according to various studies, this is impossible, and Greg must be lying. He draws himself in the womb able to speak, and claims he would do backflips; this is physically impossible, without injuring himself which he fails to mention.

Conclusion

Something that people notice in sociopaths is that their juvenile behaviour can be early signs of what they will do in the future. I believe that these diaries, journals, whatever you want to call it, are signs of Greg Heffley growing into something darker. I believe Greg Heffley is a sociopath that will grow up to be some kind of criminal or delinquent in the future. The signs are all there people. You just need to find them.